BINGZHI ZHANG

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Last updated: April 2026

EDUCATION

Oct 2021 - June 2026 (expected)	PhD in Finance Durham University
Sep 2019 - Sep 2020	MSc in Economics Durham University *Average Score: 82.88/100* *Awarded the prize for the Best Overall Academic Performance*
Sep 2017 - Sep 2018	MSc in Money, Banking and Finance University of St Andrews *Average Score: 15.4/20*
Sep 2012 - June 2016	Bachelor's in Economics Tianjin University of Finance and Economics (天津财经大学) *Major Subject: International Finance* *Average Score: 85.58/100* *Minor Subject: International Accounting* *Average Score: 85.57/100*

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Corporate Finance, Financial Intermediation, Politics and Finance, Financial Technology

PUBLICATIONS

"Up the Political Ladder: The Role of Political Networks"
with Xian Gu (Durham University), Iftekhar Hasan (Fordham University), Linda Zhao (University of Pennsylvania), and Yun Zhu (St. John's University)
Journal of Financial Stability (2026), 84, 101534

Abstract:
Drawing on detailed career and biographical data of Chinese politicians, this study builds a dynamic social network for all political elites in China and examines the selection process of provincial-level politicians. Using regression and tree-based machine learning techniques and leveraging individuals' global centrality within political networks, we unveil the relative importance of economic performance, political networks, and career trajectory in determining the selection of provincial leaders. Our findings highlight the critical role of network embeddedness.

WORKING PAPERS

"Geopolitical Risk and Bank Lending" (Job Market Paper)
with Nikos Paltalidis (University of Bath)
Presented at the DUBS Department of Finance Internal Seminar (2025) and FMA European 2025

Abstract:
Using a text-based firm-level measure of geopolitical risk (GPR) derived from quarterly earnings call transcripts, this paper investigates how banks' perceived geopolitical risk is reflected in the U.S. syndicated loan market. We find that a one-standard-deviation increase in lenders' perceived geopolitical risk is associated with a 15% increase in loan spreads, equivalent to about 30 basis points on average. This pricing response is stronger when banks extend credit to borrowers with greater reliance on global supply chains or higher international exposure, and when lenders themselves exhibit characteristics associated with greater sensitivity to geopolitical risk, such as higher foreign exposure, headquarters in politically conservative states, or lending during periods of elevated political uncertainty. In addition to pricing effects, we document a loan reallocation effect: When banks' perceived geopolitical risk is elevated, they shift new lending away from higher-exposure industries and toward lower-exposure industries.

"The Impact of Geopolitical Risk on Credit Risk"
with Christos Ioannidis (Aston University) and Nikos Paltalidis (University of Bath)
Presented at the 2nd Finance and Business Analytics Conference, 26th INFER Annual Conference, 17th International Risk Management Conference, 17th NARTI Annual Conference (Excellence in Business Research Awards), 8th Essex Finance Centre (EFiC) Conference in Banking and Corporate Finance, DUBS Department of Finance Internal Seminar (2024), and ICMAIF 2025

Abstract:
This paper investigates the impact of geopolitical risk (GPR) on U.S. corporate credit risk. We find that elevated geopolitical risk and adverse geopolitical events significantly widen credit spreads, with realized actions (wars and terrorist attacks) exerting stronger influence than threats. Geopolitical risk proves idiosyncratic, producing heterogeneous effects on credit spreads across industries and firms. These divergent effects reflect agents' different expectations, which are tied to declines in firm operating performance and amplified by firm's reliance on external financing. Furthermore, different geopolitical events also generate distinct within-industry responses, underscoring the multifaceted nature of geopolitical risk.

WORK IN PROGRESS

"When Firms Speak Up: Corporate Positioning on Social Movements and Its Financial Consequences"
with Xian Gu (Durham University)
Abstract:
This study develops new measures of corporate political position-taking by applying Natural Language Inference (NLI) models and large language models (LLMs) to U.S. firms' earnings call transcripts. We construct direction- and intensity-based stance scores across nine salient sociopolitical issues, combining logical entailment with generative AI assessments of commitment strength. Using these measures, we show that stronger corporate position-taking is associated with higher subsequent sales growth, indicating that publicly expressed sociopolitical stances can generate tangible commercial benefits. We further examine cases of "inconsistency", where firms take strong public positions but simultaneously donate to Republican candidates. Such misalignment does not attenuate the positive relation between stance-taking and sales growth. Overall, the paper provides a scalable framework for measuring corporate political expression and offers new evidence on how sociopolitical engagement affects firm performance.

"Geopolitical Risk and Knowledge-Network Spillovers"
with Xian Gu (Durham University)
Abstract:
This paper studies how firm-level geopolitical risk propagates through knowledge networks and affects innovation outcomes. Using text-based measures of direct geopolitical risk from earnings calls and a pre-period patent-citation matrix, we construct network-based exposure measures that capture downstream, upstream, and higher-order spillovers via knowledge links. We show that geopolitical shocks transmit not only to directly exposed firms but also to their technological neighbours, attenuating with network distance. Downstream exposure to risky upstream firms leads to lower innovation productivity, reduced forward citations, and a rerouting of knowledge flows toward neutral or allied sources. Upstream exposure similarly affects firms whose knowledge users are shocked, consistent with demand-driven mechanisms. Event studies around sanctions and export controls, as well as network-based shift-share instruments, confirm that these spillovers arise through knowledge-channel rather than supply-chain pathways. Overall, the paper provides the first firm-level, network-based evidence that geopolitical risk reshapes innovation diffusion and alters the topology of knowledge production.

CONFERENCES & ACTIVITIES

Presentation:

2025	DUBS Department of Finance Internal Seminar, ICMAIF 2025, and FMA European
2024	The 2nd Finance and Business Analytics Conference, the 26th INFER Annual Conference, the 17th International Risk Management Conference, the 17th NARTI Annual Conference, the 8th Essex Finance Centre (EFiC) Conference

in Banking and Corporate Finance, and DUBS Department of Finance Internal Seminar

Discussion:

2025	ICMAIF 2025 and FMA European
2024	The 2nd Finance and Business Analytics Conference and the 8th Essex Finance Centre (EFiC) Conference

Journal Reviewer: The British Accounting Review, Journal of International Financial Markets, Institutions & Money

Other Activities:

May 2026	DUBS Doctoral Society Bloomberg Training (scheduled)
September 2025	Volunteer at the International Labour and Employment Relations Association (ILERA) Regional Conference (certificate awarded)
March 2023	BSE Training Course on Introduction to Python and R Programming for Data Science (certificate awarded)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

2022-23	ECON47815 Econometric Methods (postgraduate) Practical
2022-23	ECON42115 Financial Modelling and Business Forecasting (postgraduate) Practical *Teaching rating: 5/5*
2022-23	ECON42115 Financial Modelling and Business Forecasting (postgraduate) Seminar *Teaching rating: 5/5*

HONOURS & AWARDS

June 2024	Excellence in Business Research Awards *for paper "The Impact of Geopolitical Risk on Credit Risk"* *awarded by the 17th NARTI Annual Conference*
September 2021	Fully funded PhD scholarship (2021-2024)
January 2021	Best Overall Academic Performance MSc Economics *awarded by Durham University Business School*
November 2015	Second Prize Scholarship *awarded by Tianjin University of Finance and Economics*
November 2014	Second Prize Scholarship *awarded by Tianjin University of Finance and Economics*

REFERENCES

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